Knightfall & Daybreak

Savant-Guarde

Chapter One

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Strangers To Enemies I

01

CODY

In the long, dragging years after college, all I could ever ask is to waste my life as efficiently as possible.

It's like how I'm told falling in love is supposed to be: I can't pinpoint when the feeling began, only the realization that I was stuck in it, wading through a long, dark tunnel in the passageways of my mind, praying that the distant light approaching wasn't that of another train. Maybe it was the twenty-sixth hour awake at two o'clock in the library, on that Sunday before finals, when a study partner scrolling Facebook reminded me that it was my birthday. Maybe it was turning down Kei when she asked me to go out

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to celebrate my twenty-first, preferring the cold basement of the fraternity house when I knew everybody else would be away. Maybe it was that I felt more satisfied shelving the senior project I named after my late brother than all the accolades and attention that came after it.

Maybe it was the speech my father gave at my graduation party, splurging on his male allowance of tears, saying how excited he was to work alongside me at the aerospace company. How I didn't laugh when he said my engineering drawings would have to be worthy of his tools. And how I realized I felt absolutely nothing.

But it's been two-and-a-half years since I returned to my hometown in Colorado. I reached the summit of my Bachelors' degree with too much exhaustion to take in the view, and in the two-year descent on expired passions that once got me to the top, I can't think of anything exceptional that's happened since.

Not counting today, that is.

The thought comes to me a lot in periods of idle silence. As I sit in my new townhome, celebrating the wake of another great milestone, all I hear is the white noise of my best friend snoring in sudden stops and starts on my futon, using one of the broken cardboard moving boxes as a bedsheet, rattling the mess of empty beer cans as he fights a losing battle for comfort.

It takes a moment to lift myself from the flimsy folding chair. I fight the spinning world, stumbling towards the kitchen counter to grab the remote. *Freaky Friday* autoplays on some free streaming service since I was too lazy to enter the family account. I reach to turn off the wall TV that's angled on the floor, but I hesitate — finding that I enjoy the faint sound of it over the silence.

I smile. *It feels nice to have my friend here,* I think.

The tears still wet my face, mostly from the laughter of digging up past memories, and reconnecting with a cherished childhood friend. I lift my old lacrosse stick from the ground to use it as a cane, digging my fingers into the mesh of the basket, deciding to fetch a glass of water to mitigate tomorrow's long hangover headache. But then an odd chill convects the wetness of my skin.

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I hear my parents' lecture from an hour earlier — a long diatribe on how much I wasted their heating bill by keeping my windows cracked in the winter, trying to resist my mother's menopausal "cold flashes". But this is *my* budget now, and unwilling to suffer beyond the thin sliver of disposable income after my mortgage, I hobble towards the wall, nearly in-step with Miguel's loud snore, trying to dodge the crumpled cans.

I press my hand to the window screen. The window is open, but the breeze funnels out instead of in. And when I close the window, I feel my ears pop from the rising pressure.

I remember my first thermo class: isn't hot supposed to run to cold?

So I search for the source, thinking I found my first item for the punch list. The air is dry, and when I stumble towards the source of the gusting winds — the small closet beneath the stairs — a faint, flickering light glows in the space beneath the door.

An empty can crunches when I step on it, and I realize I'm still wearing my steel-toed shoes, along with the rest of my casual work clothes. The lacrosse stick braces me as I stumble forwards—feeling like my uncle does on Ambien when he doesn't fall asleep in time—until my hand touches the freezing handle.

Tumultuous winds scream beneath the door and through the cracks, bashing the fitting against the lock. My mind doesn't work well when it's crossed, but I find myself fixated on how strange the closet door looks. I never noticed the handle, etched with an intricacy so far outside the palate of the builders' package.

Surely Mom or Dad would have noticed it on any one of the tours, right?

I turn the knob far enough that the bolt no longer withholds the gale, and I lose all my control.

The wooden door buffets me in the face. Stars flash in my vision, and if it weren't for the lacrosse stick, I would have slammed my head on the granite counter. Instead, I find myself slumped beneath the bartop, barricaded by two metal stools.

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I'm speechless until the rooms equalize in pressure, rubbing out the ache in my forehead. I lift my eyes. No longer does the closet greet me, but the light of a whole other townhouse on the opposing side.

Unable to fathom whether this dream is just the imaginings of an inebriated mind, I lift myself from the floor and stumble through the threshold of the archway. The contours of the floor change from that of smooth, buffered wood to sanded planks and stone. On the other side is another thick wooden door with the same handle, thrown all the way open. I wonder if my neighbors are so old that they insist on the technology of the last century. Who would spend the money to furnish their townhome this way, with walls and decor so aged my great-grandmother would feel at home?

It feels so wrong to be here, but I'm a social drunk, and this is a chance to make friends.

"Hello? You forgot to lock your door. Sorry to intrude — I'm the neighbor from the unit on the other side. My name is Cody, Cody Dunsmore," I say, and so I continue, stammering my words to ensure my presence isn't a surprise, though with cast iron kettles and candles, I doubt these fogies would be agile enough to swing anything at their friendly intruder.

I find a knight's uniform on the table, tailored to a woman's measurements, along with realistic metal boots.

"The old bat must be into costume play. Whatever gets you off," I mutter, but then I see the biggest surprise leaning against the wall. I try to take it in my hands, but it's so damn heavy: nothing like the weapons those mall ninjas buy at conventions.

I drop the lacrosse stick to try to lift it. Surely it's one of those real-looking swords the neckbeards buy, right?

Nope.

"Christ almighty!" I exclaim.

I try to steady it the same way I saw in the movies, but it kills my wrists. I wonder how many exercises these geriatric fantasy fetishists have to do to hold a sword like this, like holding a barbell by its end.

I put it back against the wall, and I decide to try speaking again.

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"Hello? You left your door open."

The house smells too musty to be a new build, like it's seen generations of families through its halls. Spiderwebs collect in the corners of the cabinets. The crimson curtains are bleached from decades of continuous sunlight. And when I fumble for a light switch on the walls, I find nothing: nor a single cord in this simple home snaked across the surface.

The space is dead silent in the absence of appliances: so silent that I can hear the heartbeat in my ears. Maybe I should return home to try again tomorrow.

But my plan is cut short when a shadow slides behind the front marbled glass. I haven't the time to react when the door blasts open, screeching on rusted hinges. The intruder closes the distance before I have a chance to react, blasting their glowing palm against my shoulder, casting me over their dining table with a whole handprint burned into my beer-stained work shirt.

The female knight is quick to pin me against the floor, straddling me with her bare thighs. My mind races to explain. I can only consider she's an influencer, or one of those intensely dedicated cosplayers I found LARPing on campus. Her speech is incoherent — but the longer she berates me in her mother language, drawing the prop knife against my neck as I struggle under her inhuman strength, a strange comprehension of her words overtakes me.

I feel the sentiment behind her panic. I thought she was just speaking in tongues, but I can feel my mind strain as it arranges itself to piece together the meaning of the words. And when the headache passes, I realize that I can understand her fully.

Her eyes are a golden hazel from colored contacts, and I see both of them when she looks down at me, although she covers her convincingly-scarred right eye with bangs.

She's dressed like one of those hobbyists at the Shaleborough Renaissance Faire. Her blond, silken braid hangs forward from her shoulder as she leans over me, making her look more like an angry princess than a defensive knight.

"Chill out," I say, slurring my words. "I'm your neighbor!"

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But I find the panic in her face to be even greater than mine. She rocks on my torso with every shallow breath, expertly resisting every ounce of strength I have to fight, and I feel the coolness of her cosplay armor chill the heat of my flesh as she pins my arms with her gauntlets.

"You aren't going anywhere," she tells me, tightening her grasp on my wrists. Her warm breath is on my neck as she tries to steady the prop knife, and she almost seems intimidated by my drunken composure. But it's the sudden rise in emotion that ignites something I'm even more afraid of — and I try to make it known to her.

"I think you should get off me, I—I can't control it," I say, but she's clueless about what she does to me, straddling my waist with her strong, bare thighs, the pulse of my heart quickly transitioning to my waist.

"You control nothing, thief!"

My arms are pinned beneath her legs. The pressure pounds in my skull. There's no chance to try the waistband trick, and there's only one place that all the blood can go.

"You're a fool to break into the military district. I'm a knight of the Royal Guard," she declares, as the edge of the prop knife digs into my neck.

"I don't think you understand. I can't control what's going to happen," I say, squirming with all I have.

"You pathetic weakling, what could you possibly do now?"

She has the upper hand. And all I have is a single word I learned on the Internet.

"S-S-Scaroused."

"Scaroused?" The language might be lost, but she certainly pieces together their meaning moments later.

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02

CODY

Her face flushes in mere seconds. I struggle beneath her as she tensions the knife against my neck, and when I feel the edge scratch the stubble beneath my chin, the cold steel drawing the heat from my neck, I realize it's real enough to draw something else.

"You degenerate! You lecherous, filthy animal, breaking in my house to . . . to—"

She quickly retreats, her piercing, yellow eyes assessing me with stronger eye contact than I had at my first job interview.

I lack the mental capacity to decide whether to laugh or scream. "I swear, I didn't break in here," I say, still embarassed as I cover my erection with my hands, hoping her e-girl stardom has dumbed her down enough to lack object permanence. I gesture to the closet. "The door was open. I just walked in."

She points the knife at me, then gestures to the closet. "The door was locked, you fool. And the closet? How would you break through a damn closet? There's no windows in there."

"I know, but please! I'm as confused as you are," I say, taking a breath as I try to abate the dizziness I feel from changing positions so fast. "Give me a chance to explain."

"You're excited, not confused!" She points the dagger between my legs. "You don't have the right to be confused right now." She rambles on like I actually came in to assault her. With the mental capacity for only one emotion, I settle for anger, furious about the hand I've been dealt in moving next to this crazy bitch.

She says, "I'm the one that's confused at how—"

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"—Would you let me explain? Dear God!" I say.

"It's Gods, you heretic," she says. And she looks so legitimately angry that I'm unsure whether she's spent too much time online to live in the real world. "Respect the other races. We're not the only one that shares Fosroth, and all our Gods have proven their presence."

"God, I said," I say. "A real god. Not the ones you cosplay freaks pretend to worship."

"Do you want to be executed for apostasy? Because I can do that for you, right now." Her hollow words mean little when I'm more focused on the closet. Maybe one of my eyes still wanders over her toned body and the musculature of her core — or maybe it's just because I'm so crossed on Miguel's mini-Mason-Jar mass of Mary Jane that my eyes are still crossing, too.

But she notices where I'm retreating, and in an instant, she sidesteps towards the door, using the knife to goad me away from freedom.

"Listen. What I want is to go home: not to get stabbed by a letter opener. I'm your neighbor, and the door between our units was open," I say. "I was simply trying to tell you. But really — did you have to tackle me to get your point across?"

"You do not live here. This is the Military District. Besides — you've proved that you are far too weak to live here," she says, and whether she's sold on her delsuions or not, I've still settled on anger.

"You bitch! I can bench a plate at least."

"Putting plates on benches? What, are you a fat oaf that eats outside all day?"

She looks for evidence beneath the tattered fabric of my work shirt. And I know damn well that I train arms every time I go to the gym.

I try to stand, but still don't have the balance to pull it off. So I try diplomacy, for *some* common ground I could share with this psycho cosplay chick.

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"I'm sorry to intrude. Look. I know you might be into cosplay or whatever, but this is taking things too far." I rack my mind on all the anime and movies I've seen with characters like her. Maybe if I notice, it would calm her down.

"Cosplay?" She asks, as if she doesn't know the word.

"Costume play," I say, glaring with as much disbelief as I can manage: this bitch acts like an Eskimo that's never seen ice before. "At first I thought it was old people living here: the kettle, the candles . . . I mean, the whole damn house is set up like Skyrim." I try to find a single power outlet, wondering if she footed the bill with her e-girl dollars to strip them all out of a new unit. And as I wonder how she streams on a computer, debating whether it's a desktop or a laptop, a new anger sets her over the edge.

"This is not a COSTUME!" She exclaims. I feel my body retreat backwards, towards her front door, trying to remember the door code I set so Miguel doesn't have to wake up and let me in.

She matches me step-for-step as I crab-walk towards the entrance, enumerating all the violations I'll be reporting to the HOA to get her ass thrown out.

She says, "Gods above — do you even understand how hard I worked for this? To get to this point in my life?"

"Yeah . . . lots of trips to the craft store." But it has to have been pre-made by someone: I stare at the contours of her chest armor: she's crushed in a space that was obviously designed as a men's costume.

"How hard I worked to wear this proudly as a guardian?"

"Yeah. Did you make it during the craft foam sale? I go there for the graphing pencils."

"What the Res are you on about?"

"*Mechanical* pencils," I say. "Point-five lead is like a toothpick, breaks every damn time. And yet point-nine is like writing with a fucking crayon—"

"Why do you insult me like this?" She asks. "For what, because I'm a female guard? Gods above, even the gentry — you think I'm not legitimate like all the others?"

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"No, of course not," I say, then clarify, "no, not *not* legitimate. Legit, I mean. You're very convincing. It's amazing. Steel letter opener? Form-fit foam from the craft store for the interlays, along with actual metal for some of your armor?" I ramble further on details, trying to buy myself time, but she's still hung on something I said. "I'm sure you have loads of followers like my cousin does. I know I'd follow you."

"You're too yellow to follow me anywhere," she says.

"Online, I mean."

"On what line?" And we're back in fantasy land again. "The front? You would never get close. They'd keep you busy peeling potatoes with those soft hands."

"Soft hands? Please," I say. "You're the job that banks on soft hands. While you're busy pleasuring perverts over your webcam, I work in an office. Designing the damn future. Because the rest of us have to work real jobs, not getting paid by thirsty horndogs that jerk off to Shakespeare!"

"The real work is defending the ungrateful, undeserving gentry like you," she says. "Why don't you crawl back to mummy and daddy dearest for another bump to your filthy allowance?"

She seems satisfied with her verbal assault, but I'm over it.

"Enough pretend. Your knife isn't even real," I say.

"Pray tell, does this feel real?"

She takes a slash at my arm with the letter opener. It looked so dull it could only carve butter. Her fantasies would end at actual assault, right?

Right?

But then a burning sensation scratches across the palm of my hand. The blood fountains down my arm, quickly coating the tattered edges of my favorite dress shirt with bright crimson.

The panic seizes my throat with the sudden anguish, and I'm barely able to let the words escape.

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"You . . you actually . . ." I manage, expecting surprise to flush her face when she realizes the lawsuit that awaits her. But she remains perfectly resolute, shaking my blood off a slender blade with an illegal amount of edge.

"It's time for you to leave," she says. "It's getting late, and by the Gods, I'd rather abstain from filing a casualty report tonight."

"Jesus Christ, are you insane? Do you have no boundary with your stupid fantasies? Castle Law or not, I'm calling the police!" I fumble for the door. I decide to regroup when I have the resources to fight her where it hurts. I'll report her to the IRS: no way she's paying taxes on all that e-girl money, streaming Fortnite for some gooner audience that give her enough cuck dollars to finance a townhome.

"Get out," she demands.

"You're going down for this," I add.

"I said, get OUT!"

As soon as the door cracks open, I feel the cold steel of her boot bludgeon me straight in the chest, graphing a brown-and-bloody outline on the patterned print. I roll down the stairs, settling on the stoop as my hand throbs and oozes at the rhythm of my pulsing heart: wrapping it tightly with the tattered remains of my favorite shirt.

03

CODY

I wince at the pins and needles throbbing in my hand, thinking about how I'm gonna borrow my cousin and her law degree and sue that damn bitch. Engineering might make me just enough to get by beyond the mortgage, but there's no way in hell I'm paying for medical care. I'll take an Uber to the hospital before I call an ambulance.

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Cursing under my breath makes it easier to bear. I tear the sleeve off my muddy, bloodstained shirt so I can try to wrap it up, all while I try to remember the content of my middle school health class. It's the first time I'm able to look around and take in my surroundings. The sky is overcast and pitch-dark, with none of Denver's light pollution obscuring the stars. A great body of water spans before me, which is puzzling: if I left the adjoining unit from the front, shouldn't Emerald Lake be a couple blocks away?

My housing development is devoid of streetlights by design, but when I squint to see the lights that illuminate the road, they flicker. The roads are dirty. And as I grasp the fabric of my tattered shirt as tightly as I can, plotting a large, crimson cardioid in the checkered fabric, I wonder how the HOA could ever let things get this bad with how much they say they're going to scalp me every month.

A group of five strangers approach. They hasten their walk when they find I'm on my knees: two of them far larger than I am, but all four of them far more built. They're carrying swords and wearing armor.

I don't know whether to laugh or to cry.

Hiding behind them is a furry, watching nervously. I'm distracted by how perfect their fursuit is: her eyes move away when I try to meet them, flicking the tail with some kind of servo or something.

"What is going on here? Early Halloween? Did y'all leave a D&D session? I thought it was all old people here," I say. I'm unsure whether the secondhand shame hurts more than the blood loss.

"Old people? This is the Military District," one of them says. She's a half-catgirl: half more than the full-on furry standing behind her.

She "casts fire" in their palm to give us some light. I'm impressed at how well they sell it.

The bald, black one bends down to look at my palm, still taller than my crouch at half his height. "You have got a good slice there. What happened?"

"Was it Chymaerans?" The other lunk says. The others look at him disapprovingly.

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"Enough of the Chymaeran talk, Pax," says the half-catgirl with dark hair and furry ears. "I've got the training. I can heal him."

"As in a med-kit?" I ask. "Some peroxide and a bandage?"

"No," She says. "Essence."

"What is that?" I expect it's an off-brand painkiller or holistic herbs: nothing better than a Band-Aid.

"Look — do you want my help or not?" She asks, staring me down with her cold, azure eyes: wearing contacts like the girl before, ever-so-slightly slivered like those of a cat.

I nod. "Where's the Neighborhood Patrol? I thought the cops were supposed to be out since those kids went tagging at the pool," I say.

"What in Khiras' name are you on about?" The bald one asks. He looks me up and down. "Are you sure you're from here? What's your name, anyway?"

"Name? He who asks should give their name first," I say. These weeaboos might get a kick from an anime reference if they're gonna pretend-heal me with their *Etsy* light gloves.

"My name is Ryder Zebal. This is Jullian, Aryn, Pax, and Naya," he says. Ryder the bald. Jullian the bean sprout. Aryn the half-cat. Pax the lunk, and Naya the full cat. I already forget their names before I can open my mouth, but I might as well try to befriend them.

"I'm Cody, Cody Dunsmore. I just moved here." I realize I don't have a hand to shake: my left one is being healed with what feels like glove-warmers and LEDs.

"Too strange for a Chymaeran," Pax says. "I can sense it in him. Not even a shred of Essence."

Jullian's eyes nervously cycle between the trajectory of my body and the window of my neighbor's house, watching closely. "What are you doing outside Katiya's house?"

"Katiya?" I ask. *Maybe they're all friends, feeding off each other's delusions. And if I tell too much, they'll surely testify against me.* "So you know her?"

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"Yeah," Jullian says. "We met a few years ago. Went through the service together."

"Service?" I ask. " So you're ex-military. Or National Guard or something."

"We're . . . just friends," he says, looking down.

"Friends," I repeat.

"So Katiya really lives there," Aryn says: a rare excitement in her face. "The survivor Katiya?"

"She does," Jullian says. "Why does that surprise you?"

"Just a coincidence," Aryn says.

Ryder seems to play a leadership role. As they wait for Aryn to work her dollar-store magic with hand warmers, he asks, "how about your papers?"

The word 'papers' is kinda weird, but I play along with their improv, in case they live close and I have to see them again. I reach into my back pocket with my free hand, but my wallet isn't there. I must have left it on the counter after I tipped the delivery guy.

"Hold on a sec," I say.

They reach for their swords though I can only reach one hand myself, all while Aryn is still "working her magic." I retrieve my phone from my pocket. They stare as if it were some kind of monolith. I light the screen with a tap then swipe up to turn on the flashlight.

Click.

They instantly dive backwards, frightened when the blinding flash illuminates the streets brighter than the flickering lamps. Aryn is the only one that doesn't hesitate.

"Good thing I downloaded the MyColorado App recently. Let's see here . . ." I swipe down to type M-Y-C in the search bar, and then tap the first result. They're still petrified, standing there with their swords drawn. "Very funny. You guys are great at improv," I say. "See? Right here. Class C. I can drive. Also an organ donor."

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I hold the bright screen towards Ryder. He draws closer, entranced by the display. "What kind of magic is this? Are you some kind of mage? An inventor in the Royal Court of Science? Or are you a Mask? Of the Gods?"

"I'm just an engineer," I tell them. "Hardly one at that. I design battery enclosures, not even anything interesting."

"An inventor, then," Jullian says, and I look to the full-on furry catgirl called Naya. She's hypnotized as if I shined a laser in front of her.

"Well, I should get going," I tell them, feeling light-headed. "I've got to get home and bandage this for real. It's going to—"

Then I flex my hand, and it feels like nothing.

"I have to . . ."

I turn the flashlight from the roadway, looking down at my palm, then turn to Aryn.

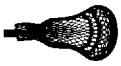
"How in God's name did you do that? Did you glue it?"

"No, you idiot. You're Human, aren't you? Don't you have the powers of fire and life?"

"No?" I say.

"Well, get on home then. It's past curfew. And we can't be responsible for you if you wander off," Aryn says. She playfully extends her arm around Jullian, leading the group off into the darkness.

04



CODY

I wait until the four of them disappear into the shadows, then I try the handle of Katiya's door.

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It's locked.

I run around the back, onto an unfamiliar cobblestone street, and counting as many houses over as it took to turn the corner, I try the window.

It's open.

I flex my left hand, still not feeling any anguish, pressing my ear to the window to try and discern where the girl is. I spend minutes listening to silence, until I hear my best friend's scream on the other side.

I throw open the window, dragging myself over the sill and depositing myself on the floor. My shoulder aches where her scalding hands burned me. I twist my body to get my feet beneath me, and manage to stand in front of the door.

And I feel the presence of the survivor girl called Katiya.

I level the lacrosse stick I used as a crutch after I lift it off the floor, tearing off the rubber end cap, flipping it around so the basket faces me. And surely enough, like a reflection in the mirror, I see the female knight standing there on the other side.

We pause there for a couple seconds. There's a panic still deep inside her eyes looking as if she's calculating whether to fight or run. I stagger my footing with my hands together on the stick, ready to body her with a cross-check, waiting for her to make the first move since I'm on the defensive.

And surely enough, the girl rushes me, but not for play. She gathers incredible speed as she dips her shoulder like a lineman coming in for another tackle, and the sober part of my mind begins to wonder if her background is actually in extorting men's wallets for cash.

Her bloodthirsty lack of hesitation to dice my palm? She has to be ex-military, but looks as if she's the same age as I am. Her outfit looks too perfect to be fake, unless she's financed it with thousands of dollars. And all the intricacies of her scars and strong, slender body look like too much of an effort to maintain unless fighting was her only job.

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The only thought on my sobering mind is the mystery of her. And as she swiftly closes the space between us, I let the hate flood my muscles with every intention to destroy her.

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